Nasturtuim Plant Care



Nasturtiums brighten container gardens and window boxes.

Nasturtiums thrive in sunny, frost-free areas across the United States, making this flower a favorite for hanging baskets, containers and in-ground planting. An abundance of blooms produced from late spring until fall range in color from brilliant yellow, red and gold to bicolors and pastels. Available in three types -- dwarf, semi-dwarf and climbing -- there is a nasturtium suitable for nearly any location. These rapid growers can be started from seed in early spring once the danger of frost has passed.

Light Exposure

Nasturtiums prefer full sun, but tolerate partial shade. Bright morning light brings these flowers to life, but they are equally at home in afternoon sun. Midday shade helps nasturtiums grown in areas with strong afternoon sun, otherwise these plants thrive with six or more hours of direct sunlight a day. Those grown in shaded areas may exhibit reduced blooming.

Soil

Nasturtiums prefer sandy soil that drains well. They adapt to a wide range of soil conditions, but rich soil may produce lush green plants with few blooms. This plant does not require more than a handful of organic matter and benefits from average to poor fertility. Nasturtiums grown in containers thrive in a mixture of

equal parts peat moss, perlite and potting soil or garden loam.

Fertilizer

Nasturtiums, especially when grown in containers, benefit from light feedings throughout the summer. A water-soluble fertilizer for blooming plants mixed to one-quarter to half-strength once a month typically provides the nutrients nasturtiums need. Too much fertilizer results in lush plant growth at the expense of blooms.

Support

Tall or climbing nasturtiums require support to grow. A fence or trellis provides the needed support for climbing nasturtiums. Some varieties reach a height of 10 feet or more and create a dazzling display of color on trellises or arbors.

Watering

Nasturtiums tolerate dry soil, but prefer moist soil and benefit from supplemental watering. They need watering deeply once or twice a week to moisten the soil to the root level. The amount and frequency of water depends on the weather, soil conditions and the plant's rate of growth. Nasturtiums in containers may require daily watering, as soil in containers dries quickly in the summer sun.

Uses

Nasturtium blooms are edible and are often used as a garnish or added to garden salads. They add a spicy flavor to foods while pleasing the eye with their bright colors. As a cut flower, nasturtiums brighten any floral display and add delicate fragrance to the home.